

A List of Developer-friendly Android Libraries

Android, by virtue of being open source, makes it easy for others to create useful libraries. This article lists twelve developer-friendly open source libraries.

The Android framework has been written to make the development lifecycle quicker, so that developers can write powerful applications in less time. Much like any other framework, there are several open source libraries available, ranging from custom views to supporting third-party components. Here is my list of favourite libraries, which I believe can save you some precious time while developing applications and ensure they are good-looking and user-friendly.

ActionBar Sherlock

This one deserves to be at the top of the list. *Actionbar* was introduced in API-11 of the Android SDK and the support library by Google does not provide a proper backport. This library by Jake Watson is now a part of almost every new Android application developed, and is undoubtedly on the top of my list. It works seamlessly with newer views such as *NavigationDrawer*, *SlidingPaneLayout*, *Fragments*, etc.

Website: <http://actionbarsherlock.com>

ActiveAndroid

This is a simple ORM solution for your applications. It is as easy as creating objects and saving them to the *SQLite* database. The setup of classes makes use of Java annotations. This saves a whole lot of time on configurations, and gives the developer more time to spend on the login than on the syntaxes. Once used, you will find it hard to live without it.

Website: <https://github.com/pardom/ActiveAndroid>

RoboGuice 2

Do you always forget to check for null when you *getIntent()*. *getExtras()*? Do you think casting *findViewById()* to a *TextView* shouldn't be necessary? *RoboGuice 2* will help

you. Inject your *View*, *Resource*, *System Service*, or any other object, and let *RoboGuice 2* take care of the details. It makes the code slimmer and reduces several common runtime errors.

Website: <https://github.com/roboguice/roboguice>

GSON

This is a powerful and lightweight *JSON* parser, specifically for Android. If you have a Web-service returning *JSON*, use *jsonschema2pojo.org* (or some other similar tool) to generate the POJOs, and with a single line of code, you can parse the *JSON* using this library. Use *GSON* along with *ActiveAndroid* and you can reduce the development time considerably.

Website: <http://code.google.com/p/google-gson/>

Crouton

This is a neat replacement for *toasts*. It is nicely implemented and highly customisable. It gives your application a notification system which is cleaner and more aesthetic than native *toasts*, and is rightly named *croutons*.

Website: <https://github.com/keyboardsurfer/Crouton>

ViewPagerindicator

This is another cool library from the developer of *Actionbar*. It makes the *viewpager* more usable and enables easier navigation between *fragments*. Users have a clear idea of where they have navigated.

Website: <http://viewpagerindicator.com/>

Rajawali

This is one of my favourites. If you are thinking of developing live wallpapers or 3D games, this library might be very handy. One can easily export the 3D models from tools like *Blender*